performance has been less impressive—victory in nine, or just over 50 per cent, of the 17 parliamentary constituencies in the state in 2019, two less than its 2014 tally of 11. The target of 100, thus, seems a bit of a stretch, especially after the party leaders have ruled out a pre-poll alliance. That the BRS is recognised as a state party only in Telangana compounds the problem as its candidates in other states, including Andhra Pradesh, will have to opt for free symbols instead of the party's 'car' symbol.

But KCR is raring to go against all odds. "Some of our enemies may not be able to digest this. But one spark is enough to light a fire. It requires self-confidence to say this, but the response is visible," he asserted at the statue unveiling near the swank new state secretariat, also named after Ambedkar. The previous evening, speaking at an iftar party hosted by the state government, KCR declared that India is waiting for the right leader and the right party, and that the TRS took on a new name in an effort to save the country.

EXPANDING FOOTPRINT

Eyeing a key role in national politics, KCR plans to embark on a nationwide tour in June, even though the BRS, say party insiders, is focusing on contesting in only three neighbouring states—Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh—for now. Together with Telangana, they account for 118 Lok Sabha seats: 48, 28 and 25, respectively. There is no word yet on the seats it plans to contest in these states.

Though, to test the waters, the party will first enter the fray in elections to about 200 local bodies and 12 of the 34 zila parishads in Maharashtra, expected to take place later this year. This, even as a BRS team led by KCR's nephew T. Harish Rao, Telangana's finance and health minister, drums up support for the "like-minded" Janata Dal (Secular) in areas with a significant number of Telugu speakers in Karnataka, before the May 10 assembly polls in the state. With an eye on the final prize, that is, Lok Sabha seats outside Telangana, the BRS has identified Karnataka's 40 assembly seats spread over 12 districts—Ballari, Kolar, Bengaluru Rural and Urban, Raichur, Koppal, Tumakuru, Chitradurga, Chikkaballapur, Yadgiri, Bidar and Kalaburagi—that have a sizeable Telugu-speaking electorate. KCR is deputing a minister each to expand the party's footprint in these districts.

In the other dominant Telugu-speaking state, Andhra Pradesh, the BRS has taken a different route to woo the locals. The party leaders have



CLARION CALL
KCR addressing a public meeting in Hyderabad

THE TRS TALLY

How TRS, the former avatar of BRS, has fared in the past two elections

